

Proposal for a Revised Structure of the MA Programmes in Political Science (MAPS) and International Administration and Global Governance (IAGG)

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June 23, 2026

Introduction

The Department of Political Science strategy for 2025–2027 identifies the development of competitive educational programmes characterized by high expectations and a strong scientific foundation as a central goal. The proposed changes are aligned with this objective.

The new structure and content of the MA programmes in Political Science (MAPS) and International Administration and Global Governance (IAGG) aim to address several challenges in the current advanced-level education structure, while remaining mindful of budget constraints (approximately 5483 clock hours, plus additional hours generated by fee-paying students) and the allocation of approximately 141 full-time equivalent (FTE) students.

The proposal is based on a yearly admission of approximately 33 students to MAPS and 33 students to IAGG, in addition to approximately three fee-paying students per programme. Furthermore, we expect around six students per programme to participate in the double degree programmes with the University of Konstanz (spending one year at the University of Gothenburg).

All calculations are approximate.

Proposed changes from admission Fall 2027

Specialized core courses in sub-disciplines in political science

By introducing specialized courses in three core sub-fields exclusively for political science students — comparative politics, political behavior, and public administration — the programme will provide a more solid and in-depth education in the discipline. Since all students will take these courses as well as the first semester courses, it will also be possible to build progression both between the first and second semesters and across the three sub-field courses. These courses will incorporate both classic and contemporary works within each sub-field.

Master seminar courses and methods seminar courses

The proposal introduces two types of seminar courses: *master seminar courses*, which focus on specific themes within particular sub-disciplines or cross-disciplinary topics, and *methods seminar courses* (including the course already decided on, SK2301), which give students the opportunity to specialize in specific research methods.

During the elective semester, students will be able to choose from several master seminar courses and methods seminars (partly implemented for MAPS students admitted in 2026). The intention is to offer topics within the same sub-disciplines as the specialization courses (comparative politics, political behavior, and public administration), while also allowing students to broaden their studies. Such broadening may occur through seminars in other sub-disciplines, such as international relations, through seminars focusing on specific themes, such as environmental politics or gender and politics, or specific methods.

Courses will be based on current departmental research while also connecting to broader research agendas within specific topics. While some seminars will be available only to students in the political science programme, other seminars will also be open to students from IAGG. This structure allows the programmes to maintain programme-specific depth while benefiting from pooled resources.

The master seminar courses will typically have approximately 15–20 students and will be based on seminars and individual supervision. Seminar capacity is dimensioned at approximately six seminars per module during the elective semester, assuming that around 60% of students remain at the department during the elective semester. In practice, the proportion remaining at the department has been lower in prior cohorts (on average approximately 45%), which would typically result in smaller seminar groups.¹

Beyond offering students more choices, these courses introduce flexibility to the programme, both in terms of instructors involved and the topics offered from year to year. These seminars typically require relatively limited formal course preparation, as they are primarily based on curated literature and seminar discussion. Each seminar will normally be taught by a single instructor.

Courses will run in parallel so that students take two seminar courses of 7.5 credits within a 15-credit module. Administratively, the seminars will be organized as sub-courses within an umbrella course of 15 credits with the director of studies as the formal course coordinator. Forms of assessment may vary and may include written exam, seminar presentations, and oral examinations. An example of the structure of a master seminar course is shown in Table 1.

MAPS from Fall 2027

The proposed new structure for MAPS from Fall 2027 is summarized in Table 2. The aim is to create a focused programme that combines in-depth specialization in political science with strong training in methods and research design.

The first semester begins with a block containing two mandatory courses, *Research Design in Political Science* (SK2302), 7.5 credits and the first of the sub-field courses *Advanced Comparative Politics* (SK2201), 7.5 credits.

The second module of the Fall semester is dedicated entirely to the methods course *Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences* (SK2301), 15 credits.

¹Historically, only one to three students choose to study abroad during the elective semester.

Table 1: Example structure for a master seminar course, 7.5 credits, running during 10 weeks

Week	Activity
1	Seminar 1
2	Seminar 2
3	Seminar 3
4	Seminar 4
5	Seminar 5
6	Seminar 6 with examination 1
7	Seminar 7
8	Seminar 8
9	Preparation final exam
10	Written exam

From Fall 2027, this course will require prior completion of a course in research design. The course serves as the core quantitative methods training for MAPS students. It will also be a relatively larger course, as it will be offered not only to MAPS students but also to students in IAGG and the Master’s programme in European Studies.

The first module of the second semester consist of two courses in two other sub-fields of political science: *Advanced Political Behavior* (SK2202), 7.5 credits, and *Advanced Public Administration* (SK2203), 7.5 credits.

The second module consists of semi-elective master’s seminars. The course *Selected Topics in Political Science* (SK2204), 15 credits will offer three seminars in which we can for example, provide an elective seminar on qualitative data collection, such as interviews and focus groups, as well as thematic seminars in substance matters in political science.

The Fall semester of the second year is designed as an elective semester. Students may either complete a full-semester internship, combine a half-semester internship with courses in the other half of the semester, follow a set of master’s seminar and methods courses, or study abroad.

During the first part of the semester (study periods 1–2), students may either begin an internship or take two master’s seminar courses running in parallel, on the course *Advanced Topics in Political Science* (SK2205), 15 credits. In practice, students would have approximately six seminar courses to choose from, three of them open only to MAPS students.

The second part of the semester (study periods 3–4) places a stronger emphasis on methods. Students may complete the second half of a short internship, take advanced methods seminars within the course *Methodological Specialization* (SK2303), 15 credits, or alternatively take the master seminar course *Advanced Topics in International and Comparative Politics* (AG2202), 15 credits, within which students choose two master seminars. These courses will also be open to IAGG students (who meet the entry requirements).

The final semester of the programme is dedicated to the Master’s thesis (30 credits).

Table 2: Proposed structure for MAPS from Fall 2027

Year	Period	Block	Course(s)	Credits
Year 1 – Fall Semester				
	1–2	Research design	Research Design in Political Science (SK2302)	7.5
		Sub-field course	Advanced Comparative Politics (SK2201)	7.5
	3–4	Methods	Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences (SK2301)	15
Year 1 – Spring Semester				
	1–4	Sub-field course	Advanced Political Behavior (SK2202)	7.5
			Advanced Public Administration (SK2203)	7.5
		Semi-elective seminars	Selected Topics in Political Science (SK2204)	15
Year 2 – Fall Semester (Elective Semester)				
	1–4	Studies abroad	Studies abroad	30
	1–4	Internship track	Internship (SK2420)	30
	1–2	Internship track	Internship (SK2412)	15
	1–2	Elective seminars	Advanced Topics in Political Science (SK2205)	15
	3–4	Internship track	Internship (SK2412)	15
	3–4	Elective methods seminars	Methodological Specialization (SK2303)	15
	3–4	Elective seminars	Advanced Topics in International and Comparative Politics (AG2202)	15
Year 2 – Spring Semester				
	1–4	Master’s thesis	Master’s Thesis in Political Science (SK2532)	30

IAGG from Fall 2027

The proposed new structure for IAGG from Fall 2027 is summarized in Table 3. An important feature of the reform is that the structure of the semesters is aligned with that of MAPS. In particular, both programmes would have their primary methods training and their elective semester in the same slots. This alignment allows students who remain at the department during the elective semester to choose courses from both programmes, thereby increasing the number of available options. The reform also addresses a recurring concern among IAGG students that the internship currently takes place too early in the programme.

The first semester begins with an introductory course, *Global Policymaking* (AG2105, 7.5 credits), which incorporates selected components from the current course AG2110. This introduction is followed by a course in research design specifically designed for IAGG students, AG2302 *Research Design and Policy Evaluation in the Social Sciences* (7.5 credits).

The second module of the semester is devoted entirely to methods training. Students may choose either the quantitative methods course *Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences* (SK2301) or a methods course offered within the Master's programme in European Studies that focuses on qualitative approaches (SF2323).² In contrast to MAPS, where quantitative methods constitute the main methods training, IAGG students may choose between different methods courses depending on their methodological interests.

The second semester serves as the specialization semester for IAGG. It consists of two specialization courses: *Actors and Policy Areas in Global Governance* (AG2110) and *Global Governance in Practice: Conflict Management and Foreign Aid* (AG2120). Because these courses are now placed after the introductory course, research design training, and methods training, they can be offered at a more advanced level than in the current programme structure.

The third semester functions as the elective semester. Students may complete either a full-semester internship or a shorter internship during either the first or second module of the semester. Alternatively, they may take master's seminar courses that are also open to students in the political science programme. During the first module (study periods 1–2), students choose two master's seminar courses of 7.5 credits each that run in parallel (approximately three courses will be offered for IAGG students) in the course *Advanced Seminar in Selected Topics* (AG2201), 15 credits. During the second module (study periods 3–4), students may choose between advanced methods seminars in the course *Methodological Specialization* (SK2303), 15 credits, or a master's seminar course, *Advanced Topics in International and Comparative Politics* (AG2202), 15 credits. These courses are also available to students in the political science programme.

The final semester of the programme is dedicated to the Master's thesis (30 credits).

Costs in clock hours for different courses

Table 4 provides examples of the approximate teaching costs, measured in clock hours, for different types of courses included in the proposed programme structures.

²The European Studies programme may offer a new course that includes both quantitative and qualitative approaches.

Table 3: Proposed structure for IAGG from Fall 2027

Year	Period	Structure	Course(s)	Credits
Year 1 – Fall Semester				
	1–2	Introductory courses	Global Policymaking (AG2105)	7.5
			Research Design and Policy Evaluation in the Social Sciences (AG2302)	7.5
	3–4	Methods (semi-electives)	Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences (SK2301)	15
			Applied Qualitative Research Methods, Problems and Design (SF2323)	15
Year 1 – Spring Semester				
	1–4	Specialization	Actors and Policy Areas in Global Governance (AG2110)	15
			Global Governance in Practice: Conflict Management and Foreign Aid (AG2120)	15
Year 2 – Fall Semester (Elective Semester)				
	1–4	Internship track	Internship (AG2450)	30
	1–2	Internship track	Internship (AG2440)	15
	1–2	Elective seminars	Advanced Seminar in Selected Topics (AG2201)	15
	3–4	Internship track	Internship (AG2440)	15
	3–4	Elective methods seminars	Methodological Specialization (SK2303)	15
	3–4	Elective seminars	Advanced Topics in International and Comparative Politics (AG2202)	15
Year 2 – Spring Semester				
	1–4	Master’s thesis	Master’s Thesis in International Administration and Global Governance (AG2500)	30

The figures illustrate that different course formats vary substantially in their teaching costs. The quantitative methods course and master’s thesis courses are among the most resource-intensive components of the programmes, while seminar courses require considerably fewer clock hours and internships require no teaching hours. The proposed programme structures therefore combine different course formats and make greater use of shared courses and seminar-based teaching in order to balance pedagogical goals with an efficient use of teaching resources.

Table 4: Approximate teaching costs (clock hours) for different course types

Course type (example)	Credits	Clock hours
Introduction courses	7.5	150
Research design courses	7.5	160
Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences (SK2301)	15	500
Specialization courses (IAGG)	15	220
Sub-field courses (MAPS)	7.5	150
Master’s seminars (each seminar)	7.5	80
Internship (full semester)	30	0
Internship (half semester)	15	0
Master’s thesis	30	1008

Entry requirements

The current entry requirements for MAPS are a bachelor’s degree of 180 credits or equivalent, including at least 60 credits in political science (of which at least 30 credits must be from in-depth courses), as well as documented proficiency in English (English 6/English B from Swedish Upper Secondary School or the equivalent level demonstrated through an internationally recognized test such as TOEFL or IELTS).

I propose that applicants to MAPS must have completed at least 5 credits in quantitative methods or statistics (corresponding to the current entry requirement for the course *Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences* (SK2301)). At the same time, the requirement that 30 of the 60 political science credits must be from in-depth courses should be removed, since this criterion has proven difficult to assess in practice.

I propose that the entry requirements for IAGG remain unchanged. The current entry requirements for IAGG are a bachelor’s degree of 180 credits or equivalent, including at least 60 credits in a social science discipline, as well as documented proficiency in English (as described above).

Admission process

The current admission process for MAPS is based on average grades from the bachelor’s degree and a statement of intent (introduced from Fall 2026).

Admission to IAGG is currently based on average grades from the bachelor's degree (from Fall 2025), completed courses in relevant subject areas, and a statement of intent. Having at least 60 credits in Political Science, Public Administration, Economics, International Relations, Peace and Conflict Studies, Global Studies, or Development Studies is considered a merit.

I propose that the overall admission procedures should remain unchanged. However, instead of assessing whether applicants have completed 60 credits in relevant subject areas, the selection criteria for IAGG should refer to holding a degree in one of these fields. This change would simplify the assessment process while maintaining the intention of prioritizing applicants with relevant academic backgrounds.

Time plan and implementation

The proposed changes could be implemented starting with student admissions in Fall 2027. At that time, however, students admitted in Fall 2026 under the current programme structures would still be enrolled and completing the second year of their studies. During this transition period, a limited number of courses from the current programme structures would therefore need to continue running to allow the 2026 cohort to complete the programmes under the existing structure.

The transition would proceed as follows:

- **Fall 2027:** The new programme structures are introduced for students admitted in Fall 2027.
- **2027–2028:** Students admitted in Fall 2026 complete the second year of the programmes under the previous structure.
- **From Fall 2028:** All courses in the programmes follow the new structure.

In particular, the course *Introduction to Applied Research Design and Quantitative Research Methods for Social Scientists* (SF2324) would need to run in Fall 2027 in order to accommodate IAGG students admitted in Fall 2026 under the current programme structure (as well as students from the Master's programme in European Studies).

Table 5 lists the courses that would be phased out under the proposed programme structures.

Concluding remarks

This document presents a proposal for revised structures for MAPS and IAGG. The suggested changes aim to strengthen the academic coherence and progression of the programmes, improve methods training, and create greater flexibility. At the same time, the changes aim to use teaching resources more efficiently.

Table 5: Courses phased out under the proposed programme structures

Last offered	Course
Spring 2027	SK2212 <i>The Quality of Government in a Comparative Perspective</i> (15 credits)
	SF2222 <i>Citizens, Politicians and the Media: Evaluating Democratic Processes</i> (15 credits)
	SK2221 <i>Environmental Politics and Institutions</i> (15 credits)
	SK2222 <i>Varieties of Democracy and Democratization</i> (15 credits)
Fall 2027	SK2211 <i>The Performance of Democracies</i> (15 credits)
	SF2324 <i>Introduction to Applied Research Design and Quantitative Research Methods for Social Scientists</i> (15 credits)